

4 THEMES

In WordPress, themes are a major part of the user experience. As with any web site, the user interface can make or break a site's capability to build traffic, expose content for discovery, and enhance user stickiness.

Finding the balance between these three areas is a somewhat fuzzy, experimental process. Most WordPress users often change their themes. Some do it to experiment to see what works best while others do it to showcase their own design abilities and to try new things. Still others change themes regularly for no other reason than that they are bored.

4.1 Things to consider when selecting a theme

Typography

User experience experts strongly agree good typography is essential, but the opinions diverge from there. Some will say that using a serif font (like the popular Georgia font) sends a strong message of stoicism and tradition while arguments on behalf of sans-serif fonts (Arial, Helvetica, and so on) send messages of elegance and clarity.

Font discussion continues beyond font type to sizing, styling, words per line, line spacing, and so on. Every user-experience professional holds to basic principles of font selection, but many diverge on specifics because it tends to be a topic of personal taste.

White space

Another common consideration when selecting a theme is white space. White space tends to make a site more readable; but, similar to fonts, do not guarantee the site will draw users. One technique is to add vertical spacing between lines of text. Additionally, you can enhance white space with ample padding and margins around images, pull quotes, or sidebar spacing. When white space is not used with care, a site can become “cluttered” and visually chaotic. Readers tend to have little patience for this kind of experience.

Fixed or fluid width

A third element to consider when choosing a theme is whether the theme has a fixed-width or fluid-width layout. Fixed-width layouts have a specific width that never changes, regardless of the size of the browser window. Fixed-